10 Teves 5785
(Erev Shabbos)

The אבודרהם, as quoted in the בית יוסף and brought down by R’ Elimelech Biderman (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications),זאָל זיין געזונט און שטאַרק, finds a source from a פסוק in יחזקאל that teaches that if עשרה בטבת were to fall on שבת, we would fast on שבת. Most other fast days are postponed when they fall on שבת, but עשרה בטבת, like יום כיפור, would be observed on its proper day. This is remarkable. R’ Biderman asks: How is it that עשרה בטבת, marking the day that מלך בבל first laid siege to ירושלים, would carry a stringency greater than תשעה באב, the day the בית המקדש was actually destroyed, which is נדחה when it falls on שבת?

The חתם סופר explains that when an earthly king like מלך בבל was granted the ability to begin the siege on ירושלים, it was because in שמים the חורבן had already been decreed. The physical siege merely reflected a spiritual reality that had already taken form.

A fast day is a time for תשובה and introspection. עשרה בטבת in particular provides us with a deeper insight into תשובה. Those who are honest with themselves understand that areas requiring improvement in their lives did not become problematic overnight. The יצר הרע gains a foothold with a single move - just one compromise, “Just this once.” But the יצר הרע, cunning as ever, turns that single concession into a habit. Every עבירה stems from that initial moment when the יצר הרע is allowed to slip through. On עשרה בטבת, we focus on the damage caused by that first move and commit to repairing it. In doing so, we begin to rebuild that which was destroyed.

There is one other situation where fasting is allowed on שבת, and that is a תענית חלום, a fast undertaken by someone who has had a disturbing dream. Even though fasting on שבת for past events is prohibited, a תענית חלום is considered a fast for the future, to prevent potential צרות. Similarly, would עשרה בטבת fall on שבת, the fact that fasting would be required indicates that it, too, is a fast for the future. By reflecting on how, years before the בית המקדש was destroyed, the seeds of חורבן were planted, we can appreciate the importance of keeping our internal fortresses strong and firm. In this way, we can merit the rebuilding of the בית המקדש.

The poignant words we recite every שבת in קָהּ רִבּוֹן come to mind: פְּרוֹק יַת עָנָךְ מִפּוּם אַרְיְוָתָא - “Redeem your sheep from the mouth of the lions.” On עשרה בטבת, we mourn the beginning of the חורבן. But perhaps today, through our awakening and efforts, we can merit celebrating the beginning of the בנין. Have a meaningful fast and a good ערב שבת.

https://youtu.be/UuizMKj7YCM